

Identification

Medical specialties defined using the American Board of Medical Specialties (24 boards, 38 specialties) and the European Union of Medical Specialists (43 sections)



Guideline-issuing professional societies identified through guideline registries (the ECRI Guidelines Trust and the Guidelines International Network), PubMed (Practice Guideline publication type), structured review of society websites, and an audit of graded guidance published in societies' own journals (June 2026; 84 candidate societies)



Clinical practice guidelines identified across candidate societies (n = 1,076)



Clinical practice guidelines screened against the eligibility criteria (n = 1,076)



Clinical practice guidelines included and extracted (n = 536; 77 professional societies, 24 specialties)



Graded recommendations extracted (n = 22,877); every evidence level mapped to the normalized scale (none unmappable)



Primary analysis — specialties with at least 5 guidelines (n = 22,693 recommendations; 21 specialties; 75 societies)

Screening

Guidelines excluded or not obtained (n = 540):

- Not openly accessible (behind a journal publisher paywall), or published only in a language other than English: 493
- No evidence level assigned to each recommendation (graded by strength of recommendation only, or not graded): 20
- Single-recommendation documents: 5
- Superseded by a more recent edition: 22

Included